

I Closed My Eyes

Everett Richards

June 9, 2026

I closed my eyes. My mind gently drifted toward the dream realm, but each time I was close to falling asleep, a conscious thought burst alight, like a shooting star above a misty mountain campfire, interrupting my descent into the night. I thought of the girl I'd been seeing, and of the unease that filled my veins every time her name lit up my phone, waiting anxiously for the inevitable discontinuation of our terminal romance.

Then I recalled some mistakes I had made in a past life, and tried, as usual, to reassure myself that the sins of yesteryear needn't bear so heavily on my conscience – but the devil hadn't folded his wicked hand just yet. I worried that I'd trapped myself in a morbid cycle of repetition – that I hadn't learned my lesson – and almost succumbed to this notion, when my father's voice jostled me awake.

I listened intently, but I couldn't make out what he was saying. His words were muffled and distorted, like the chitter-chatter of a loitering stranger when your head is submerged in a hotel swimming pool. At once, my eyes opened, and I found myself looking at an antique ballroom through the lens of a punch bowl. The silk-strewn furniture and ornate wooden walls were tinted red like chlorine-burned eyes, and the polished words spoken around me were hollow like crudely-carved pumpkins. I tried again to harvest bits of conversation, but alas, it was unintelligible.

Then again, without ever closing them, my eyes opened, and I found myself sitting upright in bed, gasping for air, and muttering dismissively under my breath. I was trying to tell myself something – something I had been hiding from myself. And I thought that if I spoke softly, I could reap the satisfaction of disclosure without reckoning with the truth. But, of course, I couldn't have it both ways. That was the cold irony: even the bleakest shroud of a whisper could not conceal my own thoughts from myself.

I closed my eyes.